that this wasn't the end, that there was still hope of seeing him again.

She pushed the main door open and skidded to a stop, breathing hard as Madame Martin stood in the center of the corridor. "Is something wrong?" Rose asked.

"I don't know. That's what I've been waiting to ask you."

She wanted to push past her and up the stairs to Léa, but Madame Martin was planted in her way, blocking the narrow corridor so Rose couldn't get round her. "What is it that you want to ask?"

"Late for you to be out on your own, isn't it?" Madame Martin eyed her blue dress and loose hair.

"I was with a friend."

"What kind of friend?"

Rose heard the lock in the door upstairs click. Maybe it was Léa coming out to the landing to listen.

"I'm tired and I'd like to go up to my room."

"Not until you tell me where you got these." Madame Martin took an object from her apron pocket and held it up.

Rose leaned forward, disbelieving. "How did you get them?"

"That's what I want to ask you." She smirked. "While you and your sister were out today, there was a complaint by one of the boarders of a leak right below your room. Of course, it was my duty to unlock the door and check the sink to ensure everything was fine. Luckily, it was, and on my way out, I saw these."

Rose reached out. "The pastels are mine. A gift. Give them back."

"A gift? From whom?"

"None of your business."

"Since you live in my boardinghouse, I make it my business."

A lump lodged in Rose's throat as Madame Martin tightly gripped her beautiful pastels. She stepped forward, determined to take them from her.

"Not so fast," Madame Martin said, slipping the box back into her apron pocket. "You need to explain how, with your sister losing her job and you earning very little as a cleaner, you had the money to purchase a box of *Pastels Girault*? Because in my mind, it doesn't make sense."

"I told you, they were a gift," Rose said. "Please, give them to me. I want them back."

Madame Martin crossed her arms at her chest. "I'll tell you what I want.